

INTERNATIONAL RELATIONS



SHIFTS IN FOREIGN POLICY

MODULE - 7

PEACEFUL NUCLEAR EXPLOSION

- 1 India conducted a peaceful nuclear test in Pokhran, Rajasthan in 1974. It was named the Smiling Buddha because it was conducted on Buddha Purnima.
- 2 Indira Gandhi authorized BARC to detonate an indigenously devised nuclear device.
- 3 This test made India the only country besides the P-5 members of UNSC to have conducted a nuclear test.
- 4 It managed to avoid being detected by USA and other intelligence agencies.



CANADIAN SUPPORT

1 Canada supported the Indian scientists with the CIRUS (Canada India Research Utility Service) reactor, technical expertise and financing.

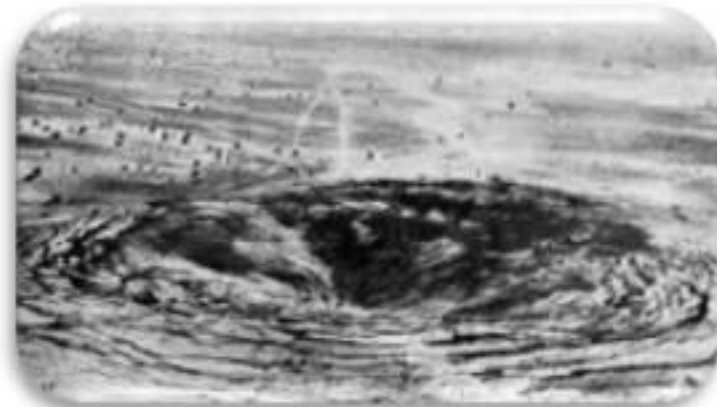
2 Canada and India agreed that the nuclear reactor would be used only for 'peaceful purposes'.

3 The United States supplied the heavy water to India.



OUTCOME OF THE TEST

- 1 This stance of Canada, however changed after the nuclear test. It cut off nuclear exports to India.
- 2 In retaliation US also imposed tough sanctions on India on the threat that the test could lead to nuclear proliferation.
- 3 The Nuclear test led to the establishment of an international body, Nuclear Suppliers Group (NSG).
- 4 NSG is a multinational body, formed to limit the export of nuclear technology and equipment and ensure it is not misused.



INDIA'S DEFENCE

- 1 India's Foreign Secretary, on the test stated that India needed to keep itself technologically updated. The test was an experiment of its technological development.
- 2 The test was intended to help India in the peaceful use of nuclear energy like mining and earth moving.
- 3 He said the test does not violate India's commitment against the use of nuclear energy for military purposes.



CRITISISM OF NUCLEAR TEST

- 1 China found the reactions of US and USSR 'absurd' as it said that the superpowers had assisted India gain nuclear capability.
- 2 US criticized India on the ground that India was suffering from economic challenges and the people of the country were disillusioned with the government.
- 3 It did not agree with India's justification and divesting its resources for nuclear explosion.



Dr Raja Ramana, Father of India's nuclear Program

END OF NEHRUVIAN ERA

- 1 PM Nehru stood for world peace and disarmament. He did not agree to suggestions of Dr Homi J Bhabha to develop nuclear technology.
- 2 He had proposed a nuclear 'standstill' agreement in 1954.
- 3 The nuclear test of 1974 seems like a departure from Nehruvian politics. But upholding the objective of national interest, foreign policy can never be and should never be static.

It should adjust according to the needs to the changing circumstances.



KATCHATHEEVU

- 1 Katchatheevu is an uninhabited islet in the Palk Strait that was formed due to volcanic eruption in the 14th century. It was owned by the Raja of Ramnad (Ramanathapuram).
- 2 There is an ancient Church in the Northern coast of the island and pilgrims from both India and Sri Lanka used to visit the island.
- 3 In 1921, both Sri Lanka and India claimed this piece of land for ideal for fishing.
- 4 Sri Lanka challenged Indian links to Katchatheevu.



KATCHATHEEVU

- 5 In 1974, the Indo-Sri Lankan Maritime agreement was signed between PM Gandhi and PM Bandaranaike. The agreement was an attempt to address the dispute by ceding the islet to Sri Lanka.
- 6 This decision by PM Gandhi of ceding by Sri Lanka was contested in the Supreme Court as it was not ratified by both Houses of the Parliament.
- 7 This agreement did not specify fishing rights and allowed Indian fishermen to fish around Katchatheevu and to dry their nets on the island.



INDO-SRI LANKAN MARITIME AGREEMENT

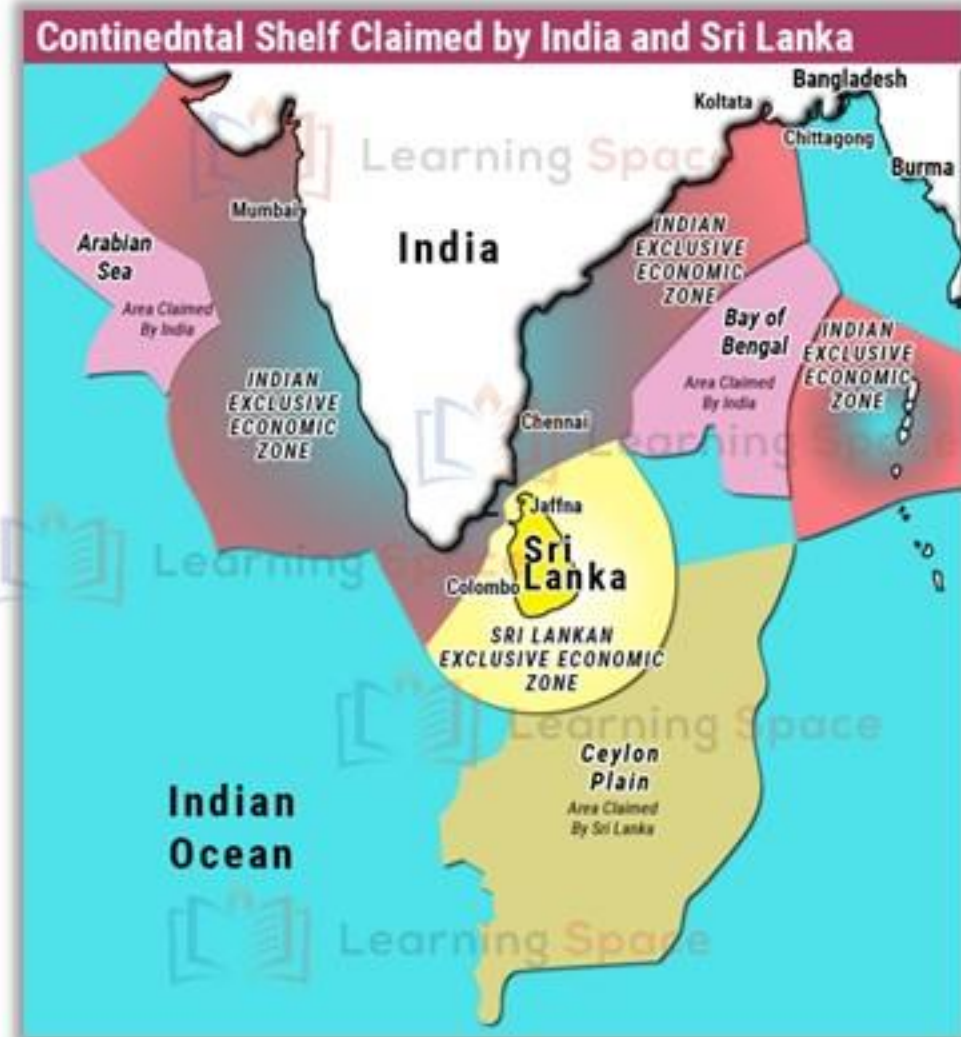
Another agreement was signed in 1976 to fill gaps of the earlier agreement. Under this

- 1** The boundary between India and Sri Lanka in the Gulf of Mannar and Bay of Bengal was determined and Exclusive Economic Zones were demarcated.
- 2** The agreement restricted both the countries' fishermen from fishing in the other's waters.
- 3** Sovereign rights over the living and non-living things in their respective zones.



WHY INDIA ACCEPTED THE CEDING?

- After the nuclear test of May 1974, India was under enormous pressure from International Communities.
- India needed some support and Sri Lanka was ready to help.
- Sri Lanka's support was also important because it was likely that president of United nations General Assembly would be from Sri Lanka.
- Moreover, Sri Lanka was to host Non Aligned Movement summit for the year 1976.
- Hence, PM Gandhi acted in the situation in 1974 without discussion in Parliament or Tamil Nadu.
- But because it is not ratified, the validity of the agreement remains a question and the worst sufferers of this indecision are the fishermen.



THE PERIOD OF DETENTE

- 1 The relations between USA and USSR improved between 1969 to 1979. This period came to be known as detente, a French word denoting the relaxation of tension.
- 2 According to Soviet Union, Detente was a formal American recognition of treating Soviet Union as an equal superpower.
- 3 US however, saw detente as a new way of containing Soviet military might.
- 4 But with the Soviet invasion of Afghanistan and Ronald Reagan's presidency, the period of Détente ended.



THE PERIOD OF DETENTE

The major achievements included

- 1** Border restriction between East and West Germany were eased in 1972.
- 2** The Helsinki Final Act of 1975 recognized a Soviet sphere of influence in East Europe.
- 3** It regulated Soviet-American nuclear arms competition. Several arms limitation treaties were signed..
- 4** In 1972, two superpowers signed the Strategic Arms Limitation Talks (Salt 1) which established limits on Soviet and US offensive nuclear weapons for 5 years.
- 5** The Anti-Ballistic Missile (ABM) treaty was signed that imposed limitations on missile defence systems and ushered in a nuclear deterrence doctrine called Mutually Assured Destruction (MAD).



SOVIET INVASION OF AFGHANISTAN (1979-1989)

- 1 Soviet troops invaded Kabul on December 25th, 1979. The domestic unpopularity against communist revolution and the growing popularity of Islamist and Western forces had to be kept in check.
- 2 The invasion was to gain access into the water ports and Gulf oilfields.
- 3 There was a threat of 'reversal of Communism' in countries like Yemen, Angola and Ethiopia.
- 4 It transformed the country and unfortunately made it a breeding ground for religious fundamentalism.



US INVOLVEMENT

- 1 In response, US offered military and economic aid to Pakistan, to provide training and other facilities to the Afghan insurgents
- 2 The Chinese also sent trucks of missiles for the Afghans through mountain pass.
- 3 US also offered to support China with sophisticated weapons to modernize its army.
- 4 After the disintegration of the Soviet Union, a vacuum in leadership was created in Afghanistan. This gave way to the rising Islamic fundamentalism in the country and support of US strengthened them further.



INDIA'S STAND

- 1 Indira Gandhi could not support the Soviet invasion as it violated the principles and foundation of India's foreign policy.
- 2 But she could not oppose the Soviet Union, especially after the 1971 Treaty.
- 3 Moreover, the invasion was in India's interests as it would affect the US-Pakistan-China axis and thus be favourable to India's security. This axis was supporting the insurgents in Afghanistan.
- 4 Thus India did not comment on the issue. But India's stand was perceived in US as a pro-Soviet policy.



DIFFERENCES OVER DIEGO GARCIA

1 Diego Garcia is an island in the Indian Ocean and an overseas territory of UK. It is strategically important to India.

2 By 1973, UK and US converted it into a military base.

3 The strategic interests prompting US intervention -

It tried to develop a naval base in the Indian Ocean to safeguard its interest in Asia.

To check the growing Russian power in Asia and the Indian Ocean area.



INDIA'S RESPONSE

- 1 India opposed South Asia being dragged into Super power politics. It was expected to threaten security in India's neighborhood.
- 2 Therefore, India wanted the Indian Ocean to be declared Zone of Peace free from Cold War politics.
- 3 India, instead, supported the claim of Mauritius which was demanding the return of Diego Garcia Island to Mauritius as its original and legal owner.



ASSASSINATION OF PM INDIRA GANDHI



PM RAJIV GANDHI

- 1 In 1984 PM Indira Gandhi was assassinated. Soon after her death, her son Rajiv Gandhi was sworn in as the Prime Minister.
- 2 Rajiv Gandhi's ideology, foreign policy priorities and approach was different.
- 3 Unlike soaring relations with US during PM Indira Gandhi's tenure, Rajiv Gandhi re-instated ties with US, particularly strategic, economic and technological relations.
- 4 His diplomacy is credited to making new friends and this approach was often welcomed by world leaders.



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